CITY OF BERKELEY
FIRE DEPARTMENT

February 5, 2026

Re: FY27-28 Fire Department Budget Reduction Memo

Due to the number of budget reduction scenarios that cannot be loaded into the worksheets, we are submitting a separate budget reduction memo to clarify our proposal. The proposed reductions include reclassifications, reductions to add pays, and changes to special funds, like Measure GG, that would offset General Fund expenditures.

In addition to this memo, we have compiled these proposals into a spreadsheet so the totals can be easily visualized and manipulated. Click here to view that.

Executive Summary

The Fire Department's FY26 General Fund total revised allocation is $53.58 million; the non-personnel allocation is $10.4 million. The Department's personnel budget of $43.1 million makes up 81% of its General Fund allocation. Sworn staff costs make up $40.9 million of the overall personnel budget and are largely dedicated to staff that work on emergency response apparatus operating from the City's seven firehouses. **Of the 214 total Department FTE, only 13 General Fund–supported positions perform non-emergency response duties.** This profile is the direct result of successive city budget reductions over multiple decades that prioritized frontline response while permanently eliminating administrative, prevention, planning, and preparedness FTE and programs.

Given this structure, a 12.5% General Fund reduction will materially degrade the City's emergency response capability. These options will have predictable and measurable negative impacts on the organization's ability to respond to fires, specialty rescues and emergency medical incidents within established time standards which will increase property loss and result in worse patient outcomes. They will further erode our ability to; conduct core administrative functions like paying employees correctly and managing grant funds; conduct required annual life-safety inspections and meet the demand for construction inspections driven by development; sustain disaster readiness; and manage responder workload – which will impact morale, injury and retention.

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Budget Context and Structural Constraints

Over the past three decades, the City has relied on the Fire Department's strong community trust to pass three no-sunset parcel tax measures **that shifted substantial fire department costs off the General Fund** while expanding services. Concurrently, General Fund reductions consistently target non-operations functions, resulting in a department that is operationally efficient but administratively thin.

As a result:

- Nearly all remaining General Fund expenditures are personnel-driven and operations-critical.
- There is minimal discretionary general fund capacity remaining outside of emergency operations.
- Any further General Fund reductions disproportionately affect preparedness, prevention, and response reliability.

Fire Department Tax Measures (FY25 Revenue Summary)

Measure M (2004) – Paramedic Services
Relieved the General Fund of the full cost of 911 Advanced Life Support ambulance transport and first-responder ALS staffing on all engine companies.

FY25 revenue: $3.95 million

Measure GG (2008)
Adopted following a substantial reduction of General Fund Fire Department overtime funding which caused temporary, rotating fire station closures. Measure GG relieved the General Fund of a substantial percentage of minimum staffing overtime costs; funded fire and police regional interoperable radio participation, disaster preparedness activities, and First Responder Advanced Life Support (Paramedics) on all emergency response apparatus.

FY25 revenue: $5.93 million

Measure FF (2020)
Addressed structural deficits that had developed in Measure M and expanded emergency medical services, training, wildfire preparedness and prevention capacity in response to increased Wildland-Urban Interface (WUI) risk and changing community hazard profiles.

FY25 revenue: $10.25 million

Collectively, these measures represent an unprecedented effort by the city, the community and labor to sustain emergency services while substantially reducing General Fund exposure.

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Critically, Measure FF was presented to voters to enhance services and capabilities, not to replace existing General Fund expenditures. Any FY27–28 budget reduction strategy that eliminates Measure FF–funded positions, programs or projects that supplants existing General Fund costs with Measure FF revenues would be inconsistent with the purpose of this tax. Such actions risk becoming publicly visible through required financial oversight and audit processes and would erode public trust. This erosion of confidence could have lasting consequences, including increased scrutiny, exposure during audits, and diminished voter support for future City revenue measures at the ballot box including the potential November 2026 Infrastructure Bond and increase to the Sales Tax.

Proposed Reduction Strategies

1. **Description: Reduce One Communication Specialist FTE**
    a. **Fiscal Impact:** Measure FF, Ongoing, $235,396 (Savings in CMO)
    b. Justification: Critical recurring fire department external community messages are captured in templates, fire department web pages are built, and having a dedicated communications specialist assigned to Fire was a luxury proposed when there was a surplus of available funding.
    c. Service/Community Impact: Potentially slower non-emergency community messaging for acute events. Planned event comms support will need to start earlier to account for less staff availability.
    d. Risk Level: Low
    e. **Mitigation Plan:** Fire communications duties including updates to the city website, community messages and some media inquiries would fall back as a responsibility of the core city communications team supported by Fire Department mid/senior managers.
2. **Description: Reduce One Associate Management Analyst**
    a. **Fiscal Impact:** General Fund, Ongoing, $233,493
    b. Justification: None
    c. **Service/Community Impact:** This will severely hamper the department's ability to apply for, track, and manage grants, as this is the only person in the department assigned to grant-related work. This individual is also responsible for tracking and reporting on the department's City Strategic Plan goals and performance metrics, which will likewise be negatively affected.

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d. **Risk Level:** Low

e. **Mitigation Plan:** Work will be reassigned to existing Administrative and Fiscal Services staff. However, that division is already busy overseeing the Fire budget, purchasing (Fire and Police), and coordinate the two most complex payroll processes in the City (Fire and Police). It is unlikely there will not be substantial impacts to the Department's ability to apply for and manage grants.

3. **Description: Reclassify two Paramedic Supervisor I to Firefighter FTE (Reclassify)**

   a. **Fiscal Impact:** General Fund, $65,754

   b. Justification:

   c. **Service/Community Impact:** Requires meet-and-confer with Local 1227. Will have an operational impact in that it will create a situation where the second employee working in this classification will lose the ability to rotate on a suppression company in order to maintain their firefighting skills (they are normally assigned to a single resource pickup truck). This is likely to negatively impact the already challenging recruitments we run for this niche classification.

   d. Risk Level: Low

   e. Mitigation Plan: Work will be re-assigned to the other Paramedic Supervisor I and to other EMS Division staff.

4. **Description: Eliminate Shift Fire Inspector Program (Add-Pay change)**

   a. **Fiscal Impact:** General Fund, Ongoing, $51,266

   b. Justification: None

   c. **Service/Community Impact:** Requires meet-and-confer with Local 1227. Smaller fires that cause limited property damage, no injury or loss-of-life would no longer be investigated. It would also cause all off-hour fire investigations to fall back to the responsibility of the Fire Marshal, which is not sustainable.

   d. Risk Level: Medium

   e. Mitigation Plan: Meet and confer with Local 1227 to establish an on-call inspector program for Sworn Fire Inspectors so that there are available staff to perform this essential function when necessary.

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5. **Description: Eliminate the City's Hazardous Materials Response Team (Add Pay change)**
    a. **Fiscal Impact:** General Fund, Ongoing, approximately $90,000
    b. Justification: None
    c. **Service/Community Impact:** This action requires meet-and-confer with Local 1227. The City would no longer have the capacity, personnel, equipment, or apparatus to respond to hazardous materials incidents. As a result, risk to the community would increase, particularly given that such incidents occur with some regularity due to the presence of the UC Berkeley campus, LBNL campus, expanding biotech facilities, and the cannabis industry.
    d. **Risk Level:** Medium
    e. Mitigation Plan: Explore mutual aid contracts with adjacent organizations, however, fully relying on mutual aid for a primary risk may not be sustainable without payment to another municipality.
6. **Description: Eliminate funding for HHCS for FTE's & Non-Personnel expenses from Measure GG**
    a. **Fiscal Impact:** Measure GG, Ongoing, $339,487
    b. **Justification:** Initial savings would be in HHCS, then the funds would be applied to fire department minimum staffing overtime, reducing the fire department overtime burden on the General Fund.
    c. Service/Community Impact: See HHCS
    d. Risk Level: See HHCS
    e. Mitigation Plan: See HHCS
7. **Description: Transition Fire/EMS Dispatch to ACRECC**
    a. **Fiscal Impact:** General Fund, Ongoing, approximately $88,000 (Savings in Police)
    b. **Justification:** The Alameda County Regional Communication Center (ACRECC) can provide modern, protocol-based fire and ems dispatching services that will provide the capacity for Fire to divert non-emergency calls away from 911 resources to more appropriate pathways.

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c. **If Berkeley maintains dispatching services, to provide MPDS and EMD internally, we will have to:**
    i. Increase staffing from 36 to 47 dispatchers @ approx. 2.2m annually (per multiple external consultant reports that have been commissioned during the reimagining process)
    ii. Meet and confer on EMD with SEIU which may carry the cost of any subsequent add pay that is negotiated.
    iii. Increase the size of the dispatch center to accommodate this staffing increase.
    iv. Pay the annual subscription fee for MPDS which is approx. 130k.
d. **If Berkeley does nothing, and retains the currently relationship with ACRECC:**
    i. Berkeley's ambulances are much busier than they should be according to an external system analysis that was performed in 2023.
    ii. The outcome of that process recommended immediately beginning to triage and divert lower acuity 911 calls and if the city doesn't, immediately deploying an additional two ambulances, which will require 16 additional FTE (~3.5m annually), to bring the unit hour utilization (time spent committed to 911 calls per 24hrs) to a reasonable rate.
e. **Service/Community Impact:** Service level to the community will remain the same or improve. Options for diverting non-critical calls to non-emergency resources will be realized.
f. **Risk Level:** Low
g. **Mitigation Plan:** 911 callers will be routed to ACRECC which is an accredited dispatch center that provides call triage and Emergency Medical Direction to callers.

8. **Description: Stand up Internal Berkeley Psychiatric Transport Program**
    a. **Fiscal Impact:** General Fund/Measure P, Ongoing, $170,000+
    b. **Justification:** When police officers and mental health workers place an individual on a 5150 psychiatric hold, transport to a psychiatric facility is required. The City is responsible for providing this service and currently fulfills this obligation through a private contract with Royal Ambulance.
    c. **Service/Community Impact:** There is no direct negative impact to the community. However, this would increase the burden on staff to support the program through hiring, additional equipment and apparatus, daily management, and personnel-related issues.

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d. **Risk Level:** Low

e. **Mitigation Plan:** The current annual cost of the Royal contract is approximately $2.5 million. Now that the Fire Headquarters facility is complete, the Fire Department can establish the necessary resources to provide this service internally for approximately $2.3 million, potentially less.

9. **Description: Reduce one Temporary Program Manager II**

   a. **Fiscal Impact:** General Fund; Ongoing, $294,625

   b. **Justification:** This PMII is a temporarily funded position through FY28 and impacts the General Fund. This role is focused on the City's innovative Street Trauma Prevention program, which aims to better align the Fire Department with the City's Vision Zero efforts.

   c. **Service/Community Impact:** Without this FTE, there would be no one in the Fire Department focused on this issue as a primary assignment. This PMII manages six internships and coordinates with Public Works/Transportation and community stakeholders. As a result, this work would suffer or cease entirely.

   d. **Risk Level:** Medium

   e. **Mitigation Plan:** Some aspects of this work may be continued by shifting responsibilities to another staff member; however, much of the work related to the Street Trauma Prevention program would need to stop.

10. **Description: Cost shift two Firefighter FTE's from the GF to UC (Henderson & Holman) by reducing the Employee Health & Wellness Program (UC Funds)**

    a. **Fiscal Impact:** General Fund; Ongoing, $539,333

    b. **Justification:** Trimming non-essential components of the employee health and wellness program would create capacity for UC Funds to support two Firefighter FTE.

    c. **Service/Community Impact:** These are non-essential educational components of the employee health and wellness program that provide employees with training on sleep, nutrition, heart rate variability, and other health and wellness topics. Reducing or eliminating these components may lead to changes in employee behavior that could impact the department's workers' compensation rate.

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d. **Risk Level:** Low

e. **Mitigation Plan:** None

11. **Description: Reduce One Fire Marshal FTE**

a. **Funding:** General Fund, Ongoing, $257,360

b. Justification: Combining two divisions (WUI and FP) that have similar missions and staff classifications.

c. **Service/Community Impact:** This will result in a general classification, Assistant Fire Chief managing the Fire Prevention Division. Previously this division has been managed by a Fire Marshal who has specific experience and education that relate to the type of work they do.

i. This is likely to increase the number of errors and omissions that occur in addition to generally decreasing the staff that are trained in fire prevention/investigation that work within this division.

ii. Fire Prevention delivers essential design review and construction inspection services; responsiveness and timely scheduling of these services may be impacted.

iii. The Fire Marshal is often involved in the review for more substantial special events, the department's ability to be responsive to the high volume of special events may also be compromised.

iv. The WUI Division is currently rolling out the EMBER Initiative, a science-backed mitigation effort designed to reduce the risk of structural ignition and large-scale fire spread when the next wildfire affects the community. While this work would continue, progress may be hampered.

d. Risk Level: Medium

e. Mitigation Plan: Staff will re-prioritize work and leverage technology to create efficiencies where possible. We can send the assigned Assistant Chief to get some education in Fire Prevention, Fire Investigation, Code Interpretation, etc.

12. **Description: One Fire Inspector FTE**

a. Fiscal Impact: $253,707, FY27-28 Only, General Fund

b. **Justification:** None

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c. **Service/Community Impact:**

   i. The loss of a Fire Prevention Inspector will reduce the Division's capacity to conduct annually required life-safety inspections of hazardous facilities throughout the City.

   ii. It will diminish our ability to perform construction inspections within the current timelines – which may need to be adjusted. This could delay construction projects and result in increased complaints to the Mayor, City Council and City Manager's Office.

   iii. This inspector is point on special events team so the department's ability to be responsive to the high volume of special events will be compromised.

d. **Risk Level:** High

e. Mitigation Plan: None. Staff within this Division are already working at full+ capacity, and there is no ability to reassign this work. This FTE was added in recognition of ongoing delays that generated complaints from developers and contractors, as well as the City's inability to complete its annually required life-safety inspections.

13. **Description: Close Fire Station 4, structural savings through elimination via attrition of 3 Firefighter FTE, 3 Apparatus Operator FTE, and 3 Fire Captain II FTE**

    a. **Fiscal Impact:** $3,631,106; Ongoing, General Fund

    b. **Justification:** None

    c. **Service/Community Impact:** There is no fire station closure that can be characterized as low-impact. The proposal to close Station 4 is based solely on its relative call volume compared to other engine companies 1,538, not because its services are less critical to community safety. The only station with fewer total responses is Station 7 at Shasta Road and Grizzly Peak Boulevard; however, closure of that station would severely isolate a geographically constrained area of the City and create an even greater operational risk than the closure of Station 4.

    The most reliable way to understand the future impacts of closing Station 4 is to examine the historical role this unit has played in emergency response. In CY2025, Engine 4 responded to 28 fires, 966 emergency medical incidents inclusive of 17 cardiac arrests, 13 auto and bike

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accidents, four auto vs pedestrian/bike accidents, 79 hazardous conditions, 230 fire alarms, and 233 other incidents. These responses represent real emergencies requiring timely intervention to prevent loss of life, injury, and property damage.

The Fire Department's total response time performance standard is 510 seconds (8.5 minutes), 90% of the time was only met 83% of the time. The travel-time performance standard of 300 seconds (5 minutes), 90% of the time, was met only 73% of the time. This means that for 415 incidents within District 4 in 2025 it took responders longer than 300 seconds to travel from the fire station to the emergency location, even with Station 4 in service. Closure of this station will further degrade performance by forcing responses to originate from more distant stations or from outside the City through mutual aid agreements with Albany and/or the El Cerrito–Kensington Fire Department. **As a result, the current total response time performance of 83% and travel time performance of 73% will substantially degrade.**

These delays have direct and measurable consequences. In cardiac arrest, each minute of delayed defibrillation reduces the likelihood of survival by approximately 7–10%. Comparable time sensitivity exists for many medical emergencies routinely handled by the Fire Department, including respiratory failure, stroke, sepsis, anaphylaxis, and circulatory shock, where early airway management, electrical therapy, intravenous access, fluid resuscitation, and medication administration markedly improve survival and neurological outcomes. Time is equally critical in structure fires. Modern residential fires can reach flashover in as little as 6–9 minutes, with fire volume doubling every 30–60 seconds. Once flashover occurs, occupant survivability declines sharply, evacuation becomes more difficult, and firefighter risk increases significantly. For traumatic incidents, including street trauma, response times of 12 minutes or longer are associated with nearly double the fatality rate compared to responses under 7 minutes.

Beyond individual incidents, closure of Station 4 creates broader system-wide impacts. The redistribution of its call volume will increase workload at remaining stations, resulting in longer travel distances, extended unit commitment times, and reduced recovery periods between calls. Over time, this decreases available time for employee training and development, elevates the risk of injury, contributes to fatigue and

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burnout, and reduces the Department's ability to sustain high-quality performance during prolonged incidents or periods of elevated demand.

First-alarm effectiveness for structure fires will also be reduced. First-due assignments are designed to place critical functions (water supply, fire attack, search and rescue, and ventilation) on scene within a narrow time window. Removing Station 4 increases the likelihood that one or more of these functions will be delayed, especially in the Northeast and Central Berkeley Hills allowing fires to grow unchecked, worsening interior conditions, delaying occupant rescue, and increasing the probability that fires extend beyond the room of origin and require additional resources to control.

Closure of Station 4 will also increase reliance on mutual aid for routine incidents, not just large or complex emergencies. While mutual aid is an essential component of regional response during surges of 911 calls or complex incidents, it was not designed for routine dependence. Berkeley already calls for mutual aid over 1,000 times per year, increasing this need will not be a sustainable solution for the City nor its regional partners.

Finally, the likelihood of delayed multi-unit responses will increase, particularly during peak demand periods. Many fire, rescue, hazmat and medical incidents require coordinated responses from multiple units within specific timeframes. With Station 4 removed, second-due and third-due units will more frequently be responding from greater distances, disrupting incident command strategies, slowing escalation when conditions deteriorate, and increasing the risk that incidents outpace available resources before adequate staffing and equipment arrive.

In summary, closure of Station 4 will increase response times across its service area and adjacent districts, degrade first-alarm effectiveness, increase responder workload and fatigue, reduce regional response resilience, and worsen outcomes for both medical emergencies and fires that occur within the North end of the City. These impacts will be felt daily and cannot be fully mitigated through redeployment or mutual aid.

d. **Risk Level:** High

e. **Mitigation Plan:** Collectively, these impacts would be felt daily and cannot be fully mitigated through redeployment or use of mutual aid.

14. Description: Eliminate Bilingual Pay (Add Pay)

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a. **Fiscal Impact:** $57,200, Ongoing, General Fund

b. **Justification:** None

c. **Service/Community Impact:** Unknown. It is presumed that most bilingual employees would continue to use their knowledge and skills to assist with translation for community members experiencing an emergency.

d. **Risk Level:** Low

e. **Mitigation Plan:** Most employees would likely feel obligated to continue providing this service without additional compensation. The City may also have language line services available that could be explored, although these have not worked well in emergency situations in the past.

15. **Description: Eliminate Medical Specialist Team (Add Pay)**

a. **Fiscal Impact:** $38,000, Ongoing, General Fund

b. **Justification:** None

c. **Service/Community Impact:** The Medical Specialist Team is a group of paramedics who receive advanced training and specialized equipment, enabling them to support high-risk law enforcement operations by providing immediate medical care to injured civilians and police officers. This service will cease to be provided to Berkeley's Police Officers in its current form.

d. **Risk Level:** Low

e. **Mitigation Plan:** Fire will work with Police to determine whether an alternative program model can provide some level of emergency medical standby without the additional pay and program budget.

16. **Description: Reduce one Fire Captain FTE**

a. **Fiscal Impact:** $408,401, Ongoing, General Fund

b. **Justification:** None

c. **Service/Community Impact:** Will weaken the Department’s ability to safely, compliantly, and efficiently administer its emergency medical services program by removing centralized oversight of narcotics compliance, critical equipment and supply management, documentation integrity, and infection control.

d. **Risk Level:** Low

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e. **Mitigation Plan:** A mitigation plan is possible but would be limited and risk-accepting, relying on the redistribution of critical duties to existing staff, reduced oversight frequency, and more reactive compliance, equipment, documentation, and infection control management.

17. **Description: Eliminate Disaster Preparedness Programs**
    a. **Fiscal Impact:** $91,000, Ongoing, Measure GG
    b. **Justification:** Eliminate the OES training contract, shelter supply replacement, internships, and conference budget
    c. **Service/Community Impact:** Staff will not have external resources to develop curriculum, maintain supplies in the disaster shelter trailers, provide internships within OES for local students, or attend conferences.
    d. Risk Level: Low
    e. **Mitigation Plan:** None
18. **Description: Eliminate five part-time FTE Cert Instructor's for Community Outreach (Hourly staff)**
    a. **Fiscal Impact: $**69,513, Ongoing, Measure GG
    b. **Justification:** None
    c. **Service/Community Impact:** The CERT program will be substantially reduced or eliminated based on available staff time. Plans for community CPR and fire extinguisher training will also cease development.
    d. **Risk Level:** Low
    e. **Mitigation Plan:** Remaining staff will try and absorb some of these programs, but most likely CERT offerings will end.
19. **Description: Cost shift General Fund contracts to UC Funds**
    a. **Fiscal Impact: $**381,566, Ongoing, UC Funds
    b. **Justification:** None
    c. **Service/Community Impact:** We reduced the scope of work for one vendor, this resulted in less health and wellness education for fire employees moving forward.
    d. **Risk Level:** Low
    e. Mitigation Plan: None

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